

plead for leniency; a loss of more than two rupees, and I would have to look for a job outside the stock market; no broker would be willing to hire me after hearing about my blunder.

I wondered if I should ask Bunty to help me out by buying the block for his fund because I had still got it at a competitive price and would gladly have sold it to him at the same price. The problem here was that Bunty's fund did not have any previous exposure to Apollo Tyres, and Bunty would find it difficult convincing his bosses about his sudden interest in the stock.

My boss was out of town and was not expected till three days later. That gave me some breathing space. I was not sure how he would react if word about my reckless trade got around to him. He was by nature a rather level-headed person, but just like the stock market, people can be irrational at an inopportune moment.

I slept fitfully that night, beset by nightmares of being chased out of the stock exchange building with just my undergarments on.

I had to drag myself to work the following day. I was unsure whether I should be going into the ring at all. With the Apollo trade playing on my mind, I was likely to make more mistakes and aggravate an already bad situation. I thought over it for a while and took a decision: I would try to first trade my way out of Apollo and only then take up other deals. I tried a bit of self-motivation so that I did not betray my desperation and make myself vulnerable to more bad deals. Maybe this was a test by God to make me a better professional, I thought, as I walked into the ring.

I inquired about the rates for Apollo Tyres. To my dismay, the prices on offer were low, and so were the volumes. I tried trading some other stocks, but my mind kept going back to Apollo. I again checked the rates, but they were still not in my favour. I decided to hold on to my position for one more day before making up my mind.

With 10 minutes left for the day's session to end, Sharma casually came up to me. We knew each other by face, but had not interacted before. The outspoken and jovial Sharma was known to be part of Harshad Mehta's inner circle. I was a bit surprised when he approached me, considering we had never spoken before.

'How goes things, Lala?' he asked.

'Surviving,' I said, forcing a smile.

'Hmm . . . we all are, in one way or another,' he said, eyeing me closely. To what do I owe the honour of your accosting me, I wanted to ask him.